

PRACTICE EXAM 3 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Practice Exam 3

The last paper. Twenty topics neither of the first two covered.

QUESTIONS 20 PAUSE 9 seconds SCORING Across all three

Before you start

- ◆ **Take this several days after exam two.** Recall after a gap is what predicts a pass, not recall on the same afternoon.
- ◆ Score by domain again, and keep both previous scores to hand.
- ◆ **Every topic here is new.** Nothing is a retest, so treat weak answers as real gaps.
- ◆ Do not take this the night before your exam. A poor score costs you sleep and teaches nothing you can act on in time.
- ◆ Answer everything. The habit matters more on the last rehearsal than on the first.

ON THE EXAM

Three papers, sixty questions, weighted across all of them to match the real exam's domain balance.

An analyst needs to answer occasional ad hoc questions about two years of application log files that already sit in Amazon S3 as compressed text. The questions arise perhaps twice a month and are different each time.

The company does not want to run any infrastructure or load the data into anything.

Which service should the analyst use?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ A Amazon Redshift | ☐ B Amazon Athena |
| ☐ C Amazon EMR | ☐ D Amazon Quick Sight |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service should the analyst use?

A Amazon Redshift

Requires loading data into a warehouse that then runs continuously, for questions asked twice a month.

C Amazon EMR

Provisions a cluster for big data frameworks. That is infrastructure the company ruled out.

B Amazon Athena

Serverless SQL directly against the S3 data. Nothing to load or provision, charged per query.

D Amazon Quick Sight

Visualises results in dashboards. It needs a data source underneath rather than being one.

THE SIGNAL

Data already in S3, occasional and varied questions, no infrastructure. Three phrases, one answer.

A company runs an application on Amazon EC2 instances. An auditor asks who applies security patches to the guest operating system on those instances, and who is responsible for the physical destruction of failed disk drives in the data centre.

The company wants a clear answer for each.

Which statement is correct?

- ☐ A The customer patches the guest OS; AWS destroys failed drives
- ☐ B AWS patches the guest OS; AWS destroys failed drives
- ☐ C The customer patches the guest OS; the customer arranges drive destruction
- ☐ D AWS patches the guest OS; the customer arranges drive destruction

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which statement is correct?

- A

 The customer patches the guest OS; AWS destroys failed drives
EC2 is infrastructure, so the guest OS is yours. Physical media handling is always AWS's.
- B

 AWS patches the guest OS; AWS destroys failed drives
True of managed services like RDS and Lambda. On EC2 the guest OS is the customer's.
- C

 The customer patches the guest OS; the customer arranges drive destruction
First half right. You can never touch AWS hardware, so the second half is impossible.
- D

 AWS patches the guest OS; the customer arranges drive destruction
Both halves wrong, and exactly reversed.

THE SIGNAL

This completes the trio. Lambda in Exam 1, RDS in Exam 2, EC2 here. The patching answer moves; physical never does.

A payments company is designing a service that must continue processing correctly if an entire Availability Zone becomes unavailable, and must return to full capacity without an engineer intervening.

It is deploying across three Availability Zones with health checks and automatic replacement of failed instances.

Which Well-Architected pillar does this design represent?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ A Security | ☐ B Performance Efficiency |
| ☐ C Operational Excellence | ☐ D Reliability |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which Well-Architected pillar does this design represent?

A Security

The word payments makes security feel relevant, but no access, encryption or audit requirement is stated.

C Operational Excellence

Close, but the recovery is automatic. Operational Excellence would concern the team's processes.

B Performance Efficiency

About resource selection and efficiency. The design is about surviving loss, not running leanly.

D Reliability

Continues correctly through failure and recovers without intervention. That is the pillar definition.

THE SIGNAL

Continue processing correctly and return to full capacity without intervention are the Reliability definition.

A security team has identified a single IP address repeatedly scanning a company's public web servers. It wants to block all traffic from that address before it reaches any instance in the web subnet.

The instances already have security groups permitting HTTP and HTTPS from anywhere.

How should the team block that address?

- ☐ A Add a deny rule to the instances' security group
- ☐ B Add a deny rule to the subnet's network ACL
- ☐ C Remove the inbound HTTPS rule from the security group
- ☐ D Add a route table entry discarding that address

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the team block that address?

- A

 Add a deny rule to the instances' security group
Security groups have no deny rules. This describes something that cannot be configured.
- B

 Add a deny rule to the subnet's network ACL
Network ACLs support deny rules and act at the subnet boundary, before traffic reaches any instance.
- C

 Remove the inbound HTTPS rule from the security group
Blocks the entire internet rather than one address. It takes the site offline.
- D

 Add a route table entry discarding that address
Route tables direct outbound traffic to destinations. They are not an inbound filtering mechanism.

THE SIGNAL

Blocking one specific address is the one thing a security group cannot do. That alone selects the network ACL.

A healthcare provider holds several million objects across many Amazon S3 buckets and does not know which of them contain patient records with personally identifiable information. A regulator has asked it to identify and classify that data.

The provider wants a managed service rather than building its own scanning.

Which service should the provider use?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ A Amazon GuardDuty | ☐ B Amazon Inspector |
| ☐ C Amazon Macie | ☐ D AWS Security Hub |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service should the provider use?

- A

 Amazon GuardDuty
Would report suspicious access to a bucket. It never looks inside your objects.
- B

 Amazon Inspector
Scans compute workloads for vulnerabilities. S3 is not a compute workload.
- C

 Amazon Macie
Machine learning and pattern matching over S3 to discover and classify sensitive data.
- D

 AWS Security Hub
Aggregates findings other services produce. With Macie switched off there is nothing to aggregate.

THE SIGNAL

Personally identifiable information plus S3 is the Macie signature. It is the only service that reads your content.

A company has run the same fleet of twelve EC2 instances continuously for five years to serve its core product. The instance type has not changed and the company is confident it will not change for at least three more years.

It wants the largest possible discount and has no need for flexibility.

Which purchase option should the company choose?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ A On-Demand Instances | ☐ B One-year Convertible Reserved Instances |
| ☐ C Three-year Standard Reserved Instances | ☐ D Spot Instances |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which purchase option should the company choose?

- A

 On-Demand Instances
No commitment and the highest price, for a workload that is as predictable as they come.
- B

 One-year Convertible Reserved Instances
Shorter term plus paid-for flexibility the company explicitly does not need. Less discount for no benefit.
- C

 Three-year Standard Reserved Instances
Longest term and least flexibility, which is exactly what earns the deepest discount.
- D

 Spot Instances
Serving a core product continuously. Interruption with two minutes' notice is unacceptable.

THE SIGNAL

Five years of history, three more expected, no flexibility needed. Every clause argues for maximum commitment.

A logistics company receives thousands of scanned delivery notes as PDF files. It needs to extract the values from named fields on each note into a structured record, and then determine whether the free-text driver comments indicate a complaint. It has no machine learning specialists and wants managed services only.

Which two services should the company use? (Choose two.)

- ☐ A Amazon Rekognition
- ☐ B Amazon Textract
- ☐ C Amazon Comprehend
- ☐ D Amazon Transcribe
- ☐ E Amazon SageMaker AI

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two services should the company use? (Choose two.)

- ☐ A Amazon Rekognition
Identifies objects and faces in images. It is not built for reading named form fields.
- ☒ B Amazon Textract
Reads scanned documents and extracts named form fields into structured data.
- ☒ C Amazon Comprehend
Analyses the extracted free text for sentiment and meaning.
- ☐ D Amazon Transcribe
Speech to text. There is no audio anywhere in this scenario.
- ☐ E Amazon SageMaker AI
Building and training your own models, which the company has explicitly ruled out.

THE SIGNAL

Two steps in sequence. Get the text out with Textract, then work out what it means with Comprehend.

A cloud programme is under way. Finance has discovered that teams can provision resources without any approval, there is no agreed way to attribute spend to business units, and the chief risk officer cannot demonstrate that regulatory obligations are being tracked. The programme director asks which AWS Cloud Adoption Framework perspective covers these concerns.

Which perspective is it?

- | | |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| ☐ A Business | ☐ B Operations |
| ☐ C Governance | ☐ D Security |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which perspective is it?

A Business

About aligning cloud investment with business objectives, not about controlling how spend happens.

C Governance

Cost management and risk and compliance management are both Governance capabilities.

B Operations

Running services day to day. Neither budget control nor regulatory tracking is an operational task.

D Security

The risk officer makes this feel like Security, but no threat, control or data protection issue is raised.

THE SIGNAL

Uncontrolled spend and untracked regulation are the two headline Governance capabilities. Both appear here.

An external auditor asks a company to provide evidence that the data centres hosting its workloads meet ISO 27001 requirements, and to supply AWS's most recent SOC 2 report. The company has no ability to inspect any AWS facility.

Where should the company obtain these?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ A AWS Artifact | ☐ B AWS Config |
| ☐ C AWS Audit Manager | ☐ D AWS CloudTrail |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Where should the company obtain these?

- A

AWS Artifact
The self-service portal for AWS's own compliance reports, including SOC and ISO.
- B

AWS Config
Reports on your resource configuration. It has no visibility of AWS's own controls.
- C

AWS Audit Manager
Helps assess your own workloads against frameworks, and is not on the CLF-C02 in-scope list.
- D

AWS CloudTrail
Records your API activity. Nothing to do with data centre certifications.

THE SIGNAL

An auditor asking about AWS's half of the model always means Artifact. You cannot produce that evidence yourself.

An EC2 instance in one Availability Zone has an EBS volume holding application data. The company is redesigning for high availability and needs an identical volume attached to a new instance in a different Availability Zone.

The data must be copied across.

How should the company do this?

- ☐ A Detach the volume and attach it to the new instance
- ☐ B Take a snapshot and create a volume from it in the other AZ
- ☐ C Enable Multi-AZ on the EBS volume
- ☐ D Convert the volume to an instance store

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the company do this?

- A

 Detach the volume and attach it to the new instance
A volume can only attach within its own Availability Zone. Detaching does not let it cross a zone boundary.
- B

 Take a snapshot and create a volume from it in the other AZ
Snapshots live in S3 and are not zone-bound, so a new volume can be created in any AZ.
- C

 Enable Multi-AZ on the EBS volume
Invented. Multi-AZ is an RDS feature; EBS volumes have no such setting.
- D

 Convert the volume to an instance store
Instance store is ephemeral and cannot be converted to. Application data would be lost.

THE SIGNAL

EBS volumes cannot cross an Availability Zone. Snapshots are the only route, because they live in S3.

During a discovery exercise before a migration, a company finds an internal reporting tool that has had no logins for sixteen months, no owner, and no entry in the service catalogue. The team that built it left two years ago.

The migration lead asks what to do with it.

Which migration strategy applies?

- ☐ A Rehost
- ☐ B Retain
- ☐ C Retire
- ☐ D Replatform

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which migration strategy applies?

A Rehost

Moving it unchanged would spend effort and money migrating something nobody uses.

C Retire

Switch it off. Discovery routinely finds unused systems, and retiring them is the cheapest outcome.

B Retain

Deliberately keeping something for a stated reason such as compliance or latency. No reason to keep this exists.

D Replatform

Swapping a component for a managed service, which still means migrating a system nobody uses.

THE SIGNAL

No logins, no owner, no catalogue entry. Retire is a real strategy and often the correct answer.

A company runs a public web application behind an Application Load Balancer. Its logs show repeated attempts to inject SQL statements through the search form, and a smaller number of cross-site scripting attempts.

The company wants these requests blocked before they reach the application.

Which service should the company use?

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ A AWS Shield Advanced | ☐ B AWS WAF |
| ☐ C Amazon GuardDuty | ☐ D A network ACL |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service should the company use?

- A

AWS Shield Advanced
DDoS protection at layers 3 and 4. Shield never reads the content of a request.
- B

AWS WAF
Inspects HTTP requests and blocks SQL injection and cross-site scripting patterns at layer 7.
- C

Amazon GuardDuty
A detection service. It would report the activity and block none of it.
- D

A network ACL
Filters by address and port at the subnet boundary. It cannot see inside an HTTP request.

THE SIGNAL

Inspecting request content means WAF. Volume would mean Shield, and detection would mean GuardDuty.

A company has grown to fifty-five VPCs across many teams, which increasingly need to communicate with each other and with the corporate data centre. The network team maintains a steadily growing number of individual peering connections. It wants one place to manage this connectivity.

Which service should the company adopt?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ A More VPC peering connections | ☐ B AWS Transit Gateway |
| ☐ C Amazon API Gateway | ☐ D AWS Direct Connect |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service should the company adopt?

- A

 More VPC peering connections
Peering does not scale. Every new VPC needs a connection to every other, which is the problem described.
- B

 AWS Transit Gateway
A single hub. Each VPC and the data centre connect once, and routing is managed centrally.
- C

 Amazon API Gateway
Publishes and manages APIs. It shares a word with Transit Gateway and nothing else.
- D

 AWS Direct Connect
A private link to the data centre, which is only part of the requirement. It does not connect VPCs to each other.

THE SIGNAL

A steadily growing number of individual connections describes a mesh, and meshes do not scale.

A company is reviewing an unexpectedly large AWS bill. It finds significant charges for data transferred from its application in one Region to users on the internet, and further charges for data replicated between two Regions.

A manager suggests that reducing the volume of data uploaded into AWS would help.

Is the manager correct, and why?

- ☐ A Yes; inbound data transfer is the largest AWS transfer charge
- ☐ B No; data transfer into AWS from the internet is free
- ☐ C Yes; inbound and outbound transfer are charged at the same rate
- ☐ D No; all data transfer within AWS is free

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Is the manager correct, and why?

- A** Yes; inbound data transfer is the largest AWS transfer charge

Reversed. Inbound transfer from the internet is free, so it cannot be any part of the bill.
- B** No; data transfer into AWS from the internet is free

Uploading costs nothing. The charges described are outbound and cross-Region, neither of which uploading affects.
- C** Yes; inbound and outbound are charged at the same rate

They are not. The asymmetry is deliberate and is exactly what this question tests.
- D** No; all data transfer within AWS is free

Right conclusion, wrong reason. Transfer between Regions and between Availability Zones is charged.

THE SIGNAL

In is free, out costs. Option D reaches the right verdict through a false statement, which still makes it wrong.

A company is preparing a business case to leave its data centre. Today it makes a large hardware purchase every three years, pays a fixed annual lease, and must decide capacity eighteen months in advance.

After migrating, it expects to pay monthly for what it actually consumes, with no advance purchase.

Which advantage of cloud computing does this describe?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ A Benefit from massive economies of scale | ☐ B Trade capital expense for variable expense |
| ☐ C Increase speed and agility | ☐ D Go global in minutes |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which advantage of cloud computing does this describe?

- A

 Benefit from massive economies of scale
True of AWS generally, but nothing here mentions aggregated demand or lower unit prices.
- B

 Trade capital expense for variable expense
A large advance purchase is replaced by monthly charges that follow consumption. The definition.
- C

 Increase speed and agility
Nothing here got faster. The company's timelines are not mentioned, only its payments.
- D

 Go global in minutes
No second Region and no new geography. Nothing about reach appears.

THE SIGNAL

The advance purchase disappears and monthly charges follow consumption. Payment shape changed; nothing else did.

An organisation runs sixty AWS accounts, each with GuardDuty, Inspector and Macie enabled. The security team currently reviews findings by signing in to each account in turn, which takes most of a week.

It wants one view of all findings and to measure the estate against the CIS benchmark.

Which service meets both requirements?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ A Amazon Detective | ☐ B AWS Security Hub |
| ☐ C AWS Config | ☐ D Amazon CloudWatch |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service meets both requirements?

- A

 Amazon Detective
Investigates an individual finding in depth. It is not a cross-account dashboard.
- B

 AWS Security Hub
Aggregates findings across accounts and runs standards checks including CIS. Both requirements, one service.
- C

 AWS Config
Evaluates resources against rules you define. It does not collect other services' security findings.
- D

 Amazon CloudWatch
Metrics, logs and alarms for operational health. It is not a security findings aggregator.

THE SIGNAL

Many accounts plus a named compliance standard is the Security Hub signature. Both halves point the same way.

A platform team runs containerised services using a large library of existing Kubernetes manifests it intends to keep. It has decided it will no longer patch, size or manage any EC2 instances.

It wants AWS to run both the control plane and the compute.

Which two services should the team use? (Choose two.)

- | | |
|--|---------------------------------------|
| ☐ A Amazon ECS | ☐ B Amazon EKS |
| ☐ C AWS Fargate | ☐ D Amazon EC2 |
| ☐ E Amazon ECR | |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two services should the team use? (Choose two.)

- ☐ A Amazon ECS
A capable orchestrator, but it does not run Kubernetes manifests. The existing library would be wasted.
- ☒ B Amazon EKS
Managed Kubernetes, so existing manifests and tooling keep working and AWS runs the control plane.
- ☒ C AWS Fargate
Removes the instances entirely, which is the second requirement, and works with EKS.
- ☐ D Amazon EC2
Exactly the instances the team has decided it no longer wants to patch or size.
- ☐ E Amazon ECR
Stores container images. Needed in practice, but it neither orchestrates nor provides compute.

THE SIGNAL

Two separations in one question: Kubernetes decides EKS over ECS, and no instances decides Fargate over EC2.

A company wants a structured review of its main workload against AWS best practices. It will answer a set of questions about the workload, receive a prioritised improvement plan, and repeat the exercise each quarter to track progress.

It does not want a service that simply watches the account continuously.

Which service should the company use?

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ A AWS Trusted Advisor | ☐ B AWS Well-Architected Tool |
| ☐ C AWS Config | ☐ D AWS Compute Optimizer |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service should the company use?

- A

AWS Trusted Advisor
Continuous automatic checks, which the final sentence explicitly rules out.
- B

AWS Well-Architected Tool
A questionnaire-based, repeatable workload review producing a prioritised improvement plan.
- C

AWS Config
Records configuration and evaluates rules. It runs no best-practice questionnaire.
- D

AWS Compute Optimizer
Rightsizing recommendations from utilisation metrics. Far narrower than a workload review.

THE SIGNAL

A questionnaire you complete means the Well-Architected Tool. Continuous and automatic would mean Trusted Advisor.

A security team is asked two questions by an auditor. Are any S3 buckets or IAM roles in the account shared with an account outside the organisation? And which IAM roles and access keys have not been used in the last ninety days?

The team wants a single service that answers both.

Which service should the team use?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ A Amazon GuardDuty | ☐ B IAM Access Analyzer |
| ☐ C AWS CloudTrail | ☐ D AWS Trusted Advisor |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which service should the team use?

- A

 Amazon GuardDuty
Detects threats and malicious behaviour. It does not audit who could access what.
- B

 IAM Access Analyzer
External access findings answer the first question; unused access findings answer the second.
- C

 AWS CloudTrail
Holds the raw evidence for the second question, but you would analyse ninety days of logs yourself.
- D

 AWS Trusted Advisor
Flags some public resources among its checks, but reports nothing about unused permissions.

THE SIGNAL

The auditor's two questions map exactly onto Access Analyzer's two capabilities. That is why one service covers both.

A company is releasing a new version of its website and wants five percent of visitors sent to it, with ninety-five percent staying on the current version, so it can compare error rates before committing.

Both versions run behind their own load balancers in the same Region.

Which Route 53 routing policy should the company use?

- ☐ A Latency-based routing
- ☐ B Weighted routing
- ☐ C Failover routing
- ☐ D Geolocation routing

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which Route 53 routing policy should the company use?

- A

 Latency-based routing
Chooses the fastest endpoint per user. Both are in the same Region, so there is no latency difference to act on.
- B

 Weighted routing
Splits traffic by proportion, which is exactly a five and ninety-five percent split.
- C

 Failover routing
Sends traffic to a standby only when the primary is unhealthy. Both versions here are healthy and wanted.
- D

 Geolocation routing
Routes by where the user is. Location is irrelevant to comparing two versions.

THE SIGNAL

A stated percentage split is always weighted routing. The same-Region detail exists to eliminate latency routing.

Scoring guide

DOMAIN	QUESTIONS	WHAT TO CONCLUDE
D1 Cloud Concepts	3, 8, 11, 15, 18	Fifteen of sixty across the papers. If weak in all three, this is vocabulary you have not memorised.
D2 Security	2, 5, 9, 12, 16, 19	Eighteen of sixty. Weak in all three means starting again at module 5, not module 9.
D3 Technology	1, 4, 7, 10, 13, 17, 20	Twenty-one of sixty. Identify the service family before rewatching anything.
D4 Billing	6, 14	Six of sixty. Only now do you have enough questions to judge this domain at all.

ON THE EXAM

Across all three papers the split is 15, 18, 21 and 6, which lands within a point of the real exam's weighting.

Reading all three papers together

- ◆ **Improving across the three** means your gaps were knowledge, and revision worked. Carry on.
- ◆ **Flat across the three** usually means a reading habit rather than a knowledge gap. Rewatch module 23.
- ◆ **One domain weak in all three** is the only result that should change your plan. Work that domain and nothing else.
- ◆ **Sixteen or more on each paper** is a comfortable position. More practice papers will not move it.
- ◆ Misses spread evenly across domains usually mean pace, not knowledge. Slow down on the qualifier words.

ON THE EXAM

Three papers is enough to see a pattern. A fourth would tell you very little you cannot already see.

You are not trying to know everything. You are trying to **separate two options that both look right.**